



SECTION A

Reading Skills

20 marks

1. Read the following passage carefully :

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- (1) Cinnamon is a spice obtained from the inner bark of several tree species from the genus *Cinnamomum*. Cinnamon is made by cutting the stems of cinnamon trees. The inner bark is then extracted and the woody parts removed. When it dries, it forms strips that curl into rolls, called cinnamon sticks. These sticks can be ground to form cinnamon powder. The spice, consisting of the dried inner bark, is brown in colour and has a delicately fragrant aroma and a warm sweet flavour. The distinct aroma and flavour of cinnamon derive from its essential oil and principal component, cinnamaldehyde, as well as numerous other constituents including eugenol.
- (2) There are two main types of cinnamon: Cassia and Ceylon. The two have different nutritional profiles. Ceylon cinnamon comes from Sri Lanka. Some people call it “true cinnamon.” Cassia cinnamon, on the other hand, originates from southern China. Cassia is cheaper than Ceylon cinnamon. Cassia cinnamon has a robust, rich, somewhat bitter flavour while Ceylon is sweeter and lighter in flavor.
- (3) Cinnamon was once more valuable than gold. In Egypt it was sought for embalming and religious practices. In medieval Europe it was used for religious rites and as a flavouring agent. Later it was the most profitable spice in the Dutch East India Company trade.
- (4) Cinnamon is widely used as an aromatic condiment and flavouring additive in a wide variety of cuisines, sweet and savoury dishes, breakfast cereals, snack foods, bagels, teas, hot chocolate and traditional foods.
- (5) Cinnamon is a spice that has been prized for its medicinal properties for thousands of years. In recent years, modern science has started to confirm many of the potential health benefits associated with cinnamon. Cinnamon has antimicrobial and antifungal properties, which is why it's often found in dental-hygiene products and is sold as cinnamon supplements. It is also a good source of antioxidants, substances that inhibit the effect of free radicals (reactive atoms that can damage cells). Due to its anti-inflammatory nature, cinnamon is currently being researched for its potential to fight Alzheimer's disease and decrease symptoms of irritable bowel syndrome and colon cancer.



- (6) Studies also suggest that cinnamon has anti-diabetic properties, and may offer protection from cancer and cardiovascular disease, among other conditions. However, more evidence is needed to confirm cinnamon's benefits. In the short term, consuming moderate amounts of cinnamon as a spice or as a supplement seems to be safe for most people. However, cinnamon contains coumarin. This is a natural flavouring, but it also plays a role in creating warfarin, the common blood-thinning drug. Consuming too much coumarin can lead to liver damage and affect coagulation.

Answer the following questions, based on the above passage :

- (i) Complete the sentence appropriately. 1
The characteristic aroma and flavour of cinnamon originate from its essential oil, primarily composed of _____. Paragraph (1)
- (ii) Based on the reading of the passage, examine, in about 40 words, how cinnamon derived from the trees is made fit to be used as a spice. Paragraph (1) 2
- (iii) Mention one point of difference between Ceylon cinnamon and Cassia cinnamon. Paragraph (2) 1
- (iv) Complete the sentence appropriately. 1
The author says that cinnamon was once more valuable than gold because _____. Paragraph (3)
- (v) What is the tone of the writer in the given lines from paragraph (5) ? Rationalize your response in about 40 words. 2
“Cinnamon is a spice that has been prized for its medicinal properties for thousands of years.”



(vi) The writer's use of the phrases 'modern science has started to confirm' in paragraph (5) and 'more evidence is needed to confirm' in paragraph (6) suggests that the benefits of cinnamon are :

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1. proven
2. scientific
3. uncertain
4. controversial
5. harmful

Select the correct option :

- (A) 1 and 3
- (B) 2 and 4
- (C) only 3
- (D) only 5

(vii) Which of the following statements about cinnamon and its health benefits is true ?

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- (A) Modern science has evidence to prove that cinnamon has many anti-diabetic properties, and it offers complete protection from cancer and cardiovascular disease.
- (B) Cinnamon lacks antimicrobial and antifungal properties, making it unsuitable for dental hygiene products.
- (C) Antioxidants found in cinnamon have no effect on free radicals in the body.
- (D) Cinnamon's anti-inflammatory properties are being researched for its potential benefits in Alzheimer's disease, irritable bowel syndrome and colon cancer.

Paragraph (6)